

Part of what's happened here is that we've used our greater wealth to buy bigger and better stuff. But we've simultaneously given up more control over our time. At best, those things cancel each other out.

Median family income adjusted for inflation was \$29,000 in 1955.²⁸ In 2019 it was just over \$62,000. We've used that wealth to live a life hardly conceivable to the 1950s American, even for a median family. The median American home increased from 983 square feet in 1950 to 2,436 square feet in 2018. The average new American home now has more bathrooms than occupants. Our cars are faster and more efficient, our TVs are cheaper and sharper.

What's happened to our time, on the other hand, barely looks like progress. And a lot of the reason has to do with the kind of jobs more of us now have.

John D. Rockefeller was one of the most successful businessmen of all time. He was also a recluse, spending most of his time by himself. He rarely spoke, deliberately making himself inaccessible and staying quiet when you caught his attention.

A refinery worker who occasionally had Rockefeller's ear once remarked: "He lets everybody else talk, while he sits back and says nothing."

When asked about his silence during meetings, Rockefeller often recited a poem:

A wise old owl lived in an oak,
The more he saw the less he spoke,
The less he spoke, the more he heard,
Why aren't we all like that wise old bird?

Rockefeller was a strange guy. But he figured out something that now applies to tens of millions of workers.

Rockefeller's job wasn't to drill wells, load trains, or move barrels. It was to think and make good decisions. Rockefeller's product—his deliverable—wasn't what he did with his hands, or even his words. It was what he figured out inside his head. So that's where he spent most of his time and